

Fasting on the Pitch: Analyzing the Effect of Ramadan on Player Performance

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Ramadan requires Muslim athletes to fast from dawn (sabah) to sunset (akşam) for 30 days, including on match days. The effect of fasting on performance has been a hot topic in football, especially in recent years as the number of Muslim players in the Premier League has grown. Despite the ongoing debates, the question has never been faced directly head on. This project aims to do exactly that: does fasting during Ramadan measurably affect Premier League player performance? One challenge in this type of analysis is that it is difficult to confirm whether a player who identifies as Muslim is actually fasting. Therefore to reduce this risk, the project uses a larger sample of Muslim Premier League players rather than a small hand-picked group, making the findings less likely to be skewed.

The primary dataset will be match-level player statistics collected from FBRef, covering Premier League seasons from 2018-19 to 2025-26. This spans six Ramadan windows and provides one row per player per match, including minutes played, goals, assists, xG, progressive carries, and kickoff time. Muslim players will be identified using an extensive Transfermarkt dataset containing profiles of over 93,000 players worldwide, filtered by nationality to flag players from majority-Muslim countries. This is enriched further by a manually compiled Ramadan date table covering 2018 to 2024. If FBRef data collection proves unfeasible, the project will fall back on the FPL player logs dataset from Kaggle, covering the 2021-22 and 2022-23 seasons. Ramadan falls within the Premier League calendar across all target seasons, giving each Muslim player both Ramadan and non-Ramadan matches within the same season to compare against.

Data Sources Link:

<https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/franeksakowski/fpl-player-logs>

<https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/xfkzujqjvx97n/football-datasets>

[Player Match Stats Finder - FBref | Stathead](#)

Context:

[Prayer Times Calendar | London, UK | March 2026 - Prayer Times and Adhan Player](#)

[Ramadan 2022: How Premier League football is evolving to help Muslim players - BBC Sport](#)
[Islam and association football - Wikipedia](#)

[Muslim Football Players in Premier League in 2023 \(Footballers list\)](#)